

The Jerusalem University

SOME PERSONAL NOTES

THE University of Jerusalem, formally inaugurated in April, 1925, as a number of Research Institutes with informal instruction, assumed in 1928 the responsibility of regular undergraduate teaching. This decisive step raised, or brought into prominence, certain definite problems, and it is in the light of these that, at the invitation of the Editor of *The Universities Review*, the following remarks are made.

Two points should be made clear at once.

First, like so many other universities, old and new, we are poor. We have few endowments and those not large. The majority of the incomes comes from voluntary annual contributions, and although these have been on the increase, the final total is by no means adequate. We live on views and prospects, as the Chancellor remarked wittily to a guest as he showed him the magnificent panorama from the University site on Mount Scopus. Second, and in this we are not like most other universities, either old or new, we are pledged to a language which, whatever other uses it has been put to, has never before been the medium of university teaching. I do not wish to be misunderstood in this. The bare statement needs qualification. There have been, and there are still, many schools both of lower and of higher learning which have been devoted to the study of Hebrew literature, while the Hebrew language has been used continuously during tens of centuries for every purpose, both of polite and of learned intercourse. But for all that, this is the first time in history that a university in the full sense of the word has been established in which Hebrew is the official language. Apart from occasional visitors, who speak to us in the language most familiar to themselves, we hear Hebrew and only Hebrew throughout. Hebrew for meetings and for minutes, for memoranda and for discussions, for lectures and for private classes—we are definitely I had almost written defiantly, a *Hebrew* university.

What the first point, lack of money, implies is so well known even in English university circles that I need hardly dilate upon it: we are strictly limited in our horizons; we work with a minimum

staff and a modest equipment (though some of our institutes have had special strokes of fortune in the shape of the acquisition of costly apparatus and of complete, and even world-famous, private libraries); we are on the eager watch for benefactors. What the second point, however, means is not so obvious, and I may be pardoned for enlarging on it. It means, to be brief, that we lack nothing less than everything in the way of instruments for teaching: ordinary text-books, translations of classical treatises, even a standardized vocabulary. It is perhaps surprising that these difficulties are felt more in the Humanities than in the Sciences. Yet after all the library of the scientific man is his laboratory, and he expresses himself largely by means of international signs. In the Humanities it is different. We deal principally with the old, not the new; and the ideas which form the standard have their standard expression. It was clear then, as soon as we assumed the responsibility of degree teaching (I may remark in parenthesis that the start was made with the Humanities), that our first duty was to try and achieve that same standard expression in Hebrew.

I take an example from my own subject, general philosophy.

It was obvious that whatever else was taught a course would have to be arranged in the development of the problems of modern thought, a course which would involve a consideration of the contributions of the founders of modern philosophy. Now, apart from Spinoza, none of these was available in Hebrew, so we set to work to make them available. The translations were prepared in the first instance by students. They were then revised, and sometimes re-written, by the staff, and afterwards hectographed, distributed at a nominal cost and used for class work. I well remember going through Descartes' *Meditations* in this way, supervising translations one week and lecturing on them the next. The result of this activity is that we have now, after less than a year and a half's work, a number of Hebrew texts in a cheap and easily available form sufficient to constitute reading for a full course in the history of the development of modern ideas, including complete versions of some of the smaller works of Descartes, Leibniz, Rousseau, Kant, Fichte, Mill and Brentano, and substantial portions of Locke, Berkeley and Hume. Of Hume, for example, we have seventeen complete chapters from the first book of the *Treatise of Human Nature*, covering a hundred typed foolscap pages, which we sell in a cheap flexible binding for a shilling. It would have been possible, of course, to save ourselves all this labour and to use texts in other languages, but, apart from enjoying the convenience of having one

text for all, we are in this way carrying out the first of our objects, the creating in Hebrew of a standard of thought and expression.

This brings me to the central difficulty we have to contend with, that of the heterogeneity both of our students and of our teachers. In England the older universities are almost completely homogeneous. They present throughout a uniformity of type depending on a uniform background of family and school, and perpetuated in the traditions of profession and class. The newer universities offer a greater variety of type but even with them the older tradition is overpowering, and it is noticeable how many of their teachers are drawn from, and too often drawn back into, the older universities. Broadly speaking, there is one standard of culture throughout the whole country.

I think I may put my point clearest if I say that this one standard of culture which in England, and in any other of the great countries, is a *fact*, is for us a *problem*, possibly *the* problem. What *exists* elsewhere has here to be *created*.

Let us take a few figures.

Of the two hundred and fifty students on the registers of the University last year, only one hundred and eighteen received their secondary education in Palestine, forty-eight in Poland, forty-one in Russia, sixteen in Rumania, twelve in the United States, five in Germany, three in Austria, three in Lithuania, two in Latvia, one in England and one in Egypt—a total of eleven countries. Assuming that they were all good men and all of the regular student type (though it must be understood that nearly nine-tenths of them have to earn their own living and count themselves lucky if, by means of work undertaken *during term as well*, they make thirty shillings or even a pound a week), we would still have the fact that they represent eleven different educational systems—of course, the present proportion of students for the various countries is accidental. This means in practice that there is no one background for any set of men one may be trying to teach.

And the same is true of the teachers themselves. Here again we have no preponderating influence of any one educational system. We have all been educated in different places and differently. If anyone wishes to understand the difficulties of university, and of any other, administration, let him come to Palestine. Everything has to be begun afresh. Nothing is taken for granted. Indeed, nothing can be taken for granted. For what can be taken for granted by a body of men who come from every country of the civilized globe and know one system only, that of the country or of the university

town from which they come? Take the most elementary things: courses of study, registration of students, syllabuses, examinations, scholarships—all those things which are settled automatically elsewhere—each and every one offers us subject for special discussion and decision, even after the various possibilities have been threshed out in committee. It is after all difficult, starting from first principles, to demonstrate the essential rightness of any one method of doing things, and we are often in the position that a Paris policeman would find himself if he tried to prove to a member of the Metropolitan Police Force, that the nature of things demands that traffic should go to the right.

And so we have no alternative. We have to create afresh, and that with much weariness of the spirit. But there is another side to the picture. Just because we have no one tradition before us, just because we have to create a new one for ourselves, we have the chance to do, we are indeed forced to do, what we came here to do. We set out to re-create a people, to re-create it morally and spiritually; and our way of doing it is to charge ourselves with the responsibilities of a people and as we test our muscles so improve them. The university was the first institution founded in the new Palestine after the war—indeed it anticipated the end of the war, its foundation stones being laid within sound of the guns—and it is the type, as it is the crown, of this great enterprise. It is the practical manifestation of the desire to find ourselves, and perhaps it is a wise dispensation of Providence that we have no one else to lean on.

What definite practical progress then can we point to set off against our difficulties? Have we so far "made good"? I reply unreservedly, and I think honestly, that we have, and that from all points of view. Three years ago we had one building; now we have three—if I may include the National and University Library, we may count four. Three years ago we were controlled mainly from without, by the international Board of Governors and the Academic Council, which nobly bore the brunt of the difficulties of the early years. We have now under the pressure of internal problems evolved a regularly working internal organization, including a fully-functioning Board of Studies on the Arts side. Three years ago we subventioned our publications at other presses; to-day we have a press of our own. Our Mathematics Institute, now housed in a special building, has a departmental library of which any university might be proud, and boasts of a staff of the very first rank. Our Arabic Department was declared by a distinguished visitor to be, on its teaching side, as good as any he knew elsewhere, while its

work in framing a concordance of Arabic poetry was said by the same authority to be "splendid." Our field archæologist is to give the Schweich Lectures this year for the British Academy. Our parasitologist is conducting a prolonged investigation for the Royal Society. The mere statement of the research conducted in our scientific institutes (I collect the figures from the recent year-book) covers a dozen pages, and the titles of their publications another dozen. It would be ridiculous to heap up self-congratulation of this sort if we were not standing on trial to ourselves. But the facts speak and are our encouragement.

What we are to look forward to, whether in Palestine as a whole or in the University in particular, we do not know. One thing, however, seems to me to be clear. The ideal of *otium cum dignitate* is not for us. Life in Palestine is a struggle and is likely to remain so. If we need anything we have to bestir ourselves. But the main thing to aim at is that homogeneity of outlook that is going to stamp the new Jew as a new man, and in that struggle the University is to the fore.

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